

SCIENCE TO EASE STRESS

At Amazon India, the first tenet is to be a scientific organisation that uses data and anecdotes to make life easier for employees, especially during stressful times

By **Binu Paul**

48 | ▶ **JEFF BEZOS HAS** a dream. And no, it doesn't involve space. What he wants is Amazon to emerge as the "Earth's Best Employer". While this dream may be a relatively recent one, Amazon India has been taking feedback from employees for long. In fact, employees begin their day by answering a single work-related question around leadership, recognition and job satisfaction. And this daily survey came in handy when the pandemic led to increased stress levels. The company quickly retuned these questions to understand how employees were feeling about safety, wellness, mental fitness and more. The HR team looked at the score on a daily basis, addressed their concerns promptly and saw the work-life harmony scores improve significantly.

"We could measure and improve employee experience quickly only because we had a tool like 'Connections'. This is part of our approach where we consider HR as a scientific organisation that uses technology wherever possible to make a direct impact on our customers and employees. We look at simple scaleable mechanisms to automate processes wherever we can instead of making them operationally heavy," says Deepti Varma, Director-HR for Amazon in APAC and Middle East. This is one of the many examples of the scientific approach of leveraging data and anecdotes that Amazon's HR team—now called the People Experience and Technology Team—deploys to innovate and invent on behalf of its employees and customers. Amazon India, which has topped the *BT-Taggd* Best Companies to Work For in India ranking this year, says it employs 100,000-plus people in the country.

During the pandemic, when employees and managers



HYBRID MODE Deepti Varma, Director-HR, Amazon (APAC and Middle East)

felt constrained about the on-boarding processes, Amazon took the help of its smart assistant Alexa to handle information that was repetitive and common. For people uncomfortable talking to Alexa, it started a chat bot. This experiment was initially carried out in India and later picked up by its global teams to hire thousands of employees during the last two years. It also introduced tech tools to conduct interviews to understand and analyse experience busters for employees and change policies in real

1	AMAZON INDIA
	Top attributes
● Clarity of company goals ● Growth and learning opportunities ● Flexibility at work	